

Contents

1 • Your Sewing Machine Setup	3
2 • Threading & Bobbin Basics	4
3 • Essential Hand Stitches	5
4 • Machine Stitches You Need	7
5 • Seam Allowances & Finishing	8
6 • Pressing Like a Pro	9
7 • Pins, Needles & Thread Selection	10
Next Step	12

Your Sewing Machine Setup

Set up your machine correctly so it runs smoothly from the very first stitch.

A well-set-up machine prevents 90% of beginner frustrations — skipped stitches, thread jams and uneven tension all start here.

Step by step

- 1 Place your machine on a sturdy, flat surface** — vibration causes uneven stitches on wobbly tables.
- 2 Plug in and test the foot pedal** — press gently to confirm smooth speed control before threading.
- 3 Raise the presser foot and insert your needle** — flat side facing back, pushed all the way up, then tighten the screw.
- 4 Wind a bobbin with your chosen thread** — follow the guides printed on your machine for the winding path.
- 5 Thread the upper path following the numbered guides** — most machines print small numbers along the thread path.
- 6 Pull up the bobbin thread** — hold the upper thread, turn the handwheel one full rotation toward you, then pull both threads to the back.

Do this

Always thread with the presser foot UP — this opens the tension discs so the thread seats properly.

Common mistake

Threading with the presser foot down traps the thread outside the tension discs, causing loose, loopy stitches on the underside.

Threading & Bobbin Basics

Thread your machine and wind bobbins with confidence every time.

Consistent thread tension starts with correct threading — if the thread is in the right place, the machine does the rest.

Bobbin troubleshooting

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Bobbin thread bunches underneath	Upper thread not seated in tension discs	Re-thread with presser foot up
Bobbin won't wind evenly	Thread not in the bobbin winding guide	Re-route through the small guide above the spool pin
Thread breaks mid-stitch	Needle inserted incorrectly or bent	Replace needle, flat side to the back
Stitches skip	Wrong needle size for the fabric	Match needle to fabric weight (see Section 7)

Before you start sewing — check

- ☐ Presser foot is up while threading
- ☐ Thread follows every guide in order
- ☐ Bobbin is wound evenly and not overfilled
- ☐ Both threads are pulled to the back under the presser foot
- ☐ Needle is the right type and size for your fabric

Essential Hand Stitches

Learn five hand stitches that cover every alteration situation where a machine cannot reach.

Hand stitching is not a fallback — it is the right tool for hems, closures and repairs where an invisible finish matters.

The five stitches you need

- 1 Running stitch** — the simplest: in-out-in-out, even spacing. Use for basting (temporary hold) before machine sewing.
- 2 Backstitch** — strongest hand stitch. Each stitch goes back to meet the previous one. Use for seam repairs.
- 3 Slip stitch (blind hem)** — nearly invisible from the outside. Catch one thread of the outer fabric, then travel inside the fold. Use for hems.
- 4 Whip stitch** — angled stitches that wrap over the edge. Use for finishing raw edges and attaching hooks or eyes.
- 5 Catch stitch (herringbone)** — X-shaped stitches that allow stretch. Use for hemming knit fabrics.

When to hand-stitch

- Blind hems on dresses and trousers
- Lining closures
- Button reattachment
- Hook-and-eye installation

When to use a machine

- Structural seams under stress
- Topstitching for a professional look
- Long straight hems on curtains
- Zigzag edge finishing

Do this

Use a single strand of thread no longer than your forearm — longer threads tangle and weaken from friction as you pull them through.

Machine Stitches You Need

Know which stitch setting to choose for each type of fabric and seam.

Most alterations use just three machine stitches — straight, zigzag and blind hem. Master these and you cover 95% of all sewing tasks.

STITCH	SETTING	BEST FOR	LENGTH
Straight stitch	Center needle position	Seams, topstitching, darts	2.5 mm
Zigzag	Medium width, medium length	Finishing raw edges, stretch fabrics	2.0 mm wide, 2.0 mm long
Blind hem	Blind hem foot + stitch	Invisible hems on trousers and skirts	Per machine guide
Basting stitch	Longest straight stitch	Temporary hold, easy to remove	5.0 mm
Backstitch (reverse)	Hold reverse lever	Securing stitch start and end	Same as straight

Common mistake

Forgetting to backstitch at the start and end of a seam — without it, your stitches unravel the first time the garment is worn.

Seam Allowances & Finishing

Understand seam allowances so you cut and sew with precision every time.

A seam allowance is the strip of fabric between the stitching line and the raw edge. Getting it right is the difference between a garment that fits and one that is too tight or too loose.

Standard seam allowances

ALLOWANCE	WHERE IT IS USED
1.5 cm ($\frac{5}{8}$ inch)	Standard for most home sewing patterns
1.0 cm ($\frac{3}{8}$ inch)	Commercial ready-to-wear garments
0.6 cm ($\frac{1}{4}$ inch)	Collars, facings, curved seams after trimming

Edge finishing methods

- 1 Zigzag the raw edge** — fast, uses only your machine. Stitch close to the edge without going over it.
- 2 Pinking shears** — cut a zigzag edge that resists fraying. Works on woven fabrics, not knits.
- 3 French seam** — encloses the raw edge inside the seam for a clean finish on both sides.
- 4 Bias binding** — wraps the raw edge in a strip of bias-cut fabric. Best for armholes and necklines.

Pressing Like a Pro

Press every seam as you sew — it is the single habit that separates amateur work from professional results.

Pressing is not ironing. Ironing slides the iron back and forth; pressing lifts and lowers it in place. Sliding distorts seams and stretches bias edges.

Pressing rules

- 1 Press every seam before crossing it with another** — flat seams make accurate intersections.
- 2 Press seams open unless the pattern says otherwise** — open seams lie flatter and distribute bulk.
- 3 Use a pressing cloth on delicate fabrics** — a piece of muslin between the iron and the fabric prevents shine and scorch marks.
- 4 Press darts toward the center of the garment** — bust darts press down, back darts press toward center back.
- 5 Let the fabric cool before moving it** — fabric takes its shape while cooling, not while hot.

Do this

Keep a small spray bottle of water next to your iron. A light mist before pressing sets creases sharply on cotton and linen.

Common mistake

Pressing a fold before checking the measurement — once creased, the line is hard to remove. Measure twice, press once.

Pins, Needles & Thread Selection

Choose the right needle and thread for any fabric so your stitches hold and your fabric stays undamaged.

The wrong needle punches holes; the wrong thread breaks or puckers. Matching both to your fabric takes thirty seconds and prevents hours of frustration.

Needle guide

FABRIC TYPE	NEEDLE TYPE	SIZE
Lightweight (chiffon, silk, voile)	Universal or Microtex	60/8 – 70/10
Medium weight (cotton, linen, poplin)	Universal	80/12
Heavy weight (denim, canvas, twill)	Jeans	90/14 – 100/16
Knits (jersey, interlock, fleece)	Ballpoint / Jersey	75/11 – 90/14
Stretch (lycra, spandex blends)	Stretch	75/11 – 90/14

Thread guide

THREAD	BEST FOR
All-purpose polyester	Most alterations — strong, slight stretch, colourfast
Cotton thread	Natural fibre fabrics when you want the thread to press flat
Heavy-duty polyester	Denim, upholstery, bag straps
Invisible (monofilament)	Blind hems where thread colour match is impossible

Quick-match checklist

- ☐ Needle type matches fabric type (woven vs knit)
- ☐ Needle size matches fabric weight
- ☐ Thread colour matches or is one shade darker
- ☐ Thread weight matches needle size
- ☐ Needle is fresh (change every 8 hours of sewing)

Next Step

Open **The Complete Clothing Alterations Manual** and start with Guide 1 in Chapter 1. Use this refresher as your go-to reference whenever you need to check a stitch, a needle size or a pressing technique.